largest building) and protested his assignment—he wanted to be sent to the front. But once he learned more about the potential outcome of the work, he warmed to it. Groves selected the Berkeley physicist Robert Oppenheimer as the scientific director of the top-secret project, code-named Manhattan. Under the “peculiar sovereignty” of the Manhattan Project, Fermi, Wigner, and other refugee European physicists joined their American colleagues at Los Alamos, high in the New Mexico desert, to build a bomb, racing against their German rivals.

Many physicists at Los Alamos thought the Nazis had a head start on nuclear power, and they had good reason to think so. Germany had been the center of the physics world for generations, and America had long been considered a scientific backwater. Fission, after all, had been first discovered in Germany. Germany had also been in the war longer, and thanks to Hitler’s invasion of Czechoslovakia, it had access to vast uranium resources. And, despite Hitler’s racist civil service laws, many good physicists remained in the country. Otto Hahn, the nuclear chemist who discovered fission, stayed in Germany, though he wanted nothing to do with the Nazis. Instead, he quietly continued his research, protecting his Jewish colleagues where he could and corresponding with the ones in exile, like Meitner and Frisch. Hahn’s friend, the Nobel Prize–winning physicist Max von Laue, took his opposition one step further and risked his life by repeatedly and publicly condemning Hitler’s regime from within. But most German physicists didn’t follow Hahn’s example, and almost none took von Laue’s principled stance. And some, like Pascual Jordan, eagerly aided Hitler’s regime. Finding the Nazi ideology appealing for aesthetic reasons—and in line with his idealist stance on the philosophy of science—Jordan joined not only the Nazi Party in 1933, but also the Brownshirts, Hitler’s paramilitary storm troopers. And other physicists, like Johannes Stark and Philipp Lenard, had been Nazis even before Hitler came to power, and applied Hitler’s racial “philosophy” to physics, declaring relativity and quantum theory to be “Jewish physics.”

Werner Heisenberg fell somewhere between the extremes of von Laue’s